

Part 1: Environment Setup — Zero to Ready

Video: Build ServiceNow Apps with AI (From Scratch)

No assumptions. We install everything from zero. By the end of this part, your machine is fully ready to build ServiceNow apps with AI.

What We're Installing

#	Tool	Why
1	VS Code	Code editor — the base for everything
2	Node.js + NPM	Runtime + package manager — needed to install everything else
3	Claude Code	AI coding assistant that runs in your terminal
4	ServiceNow SDK	The official SDK to build ServiceNow apps as code
5	GitHub Copilot (optional)	AI assistant inside VS Code
6	Windsurf (optional)	AI-native code editor

Step 1: Install VS Code

Mac

1. Go to <https://code.visualstudio.com>
2. Click **Download for Mac**
3. Open the downloaded **.zip** file
4. Drag **Visual Studio Code** into your **Applications** folder
5. Open VS Code from Applications
6. (Optional) Add **code** to your terminal PATH:

- Press **Cmd + Shift + P** → type **"Shell Command"**
- Select **"Shell Command: Install 'code' command in PATH"**

Windows

1. Go to <https://code.visualstudio.com>
2. Click **Download for Windows**
3. Run the installer (.exe file)
4. **Important:** Check ☒ "Add to PATH" during installation
5. Click Install → Finish
6. Open VS Code from the Start menu

Verify

Open VS Code. You should see the Welcome tab. That's it — VS Code is ready.

Step 2: Install Node.js + NPM

NPM (Node Package Manager) comes bundled with Node.js. We need this before we can install Claude Code or the ServiceNow SDK.

Mac

1. Go to <https://nodejs.org>
2. Download the **LTS** version (not Current)
3. Open the .pkg file and follow the installer
4. Open **Terminal** (Cmd + Space → type "Terminal")
5. Verify installation:

```
node -v
# Should show something like: v22.x.x
```

```
npm -v
# Should show something like: 10.x.x
```

Windows

1. Go to <https://nodejs.org>
2. Download the **LTS** version
3. Run the .msi installer
4. Click Next through all steps (keep defaults)

5. **Important:** Make sure "Add to PATH" is checked

6. Open **Command Prompt** or **PowerShell**

7. Verify:

```
node -v
npm -v
```

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
node: command not found	Close and reopen your terminal. If still broken, reinstall Node and check "Add to PATH"
Old version showing	Uninstall old Node first, then install fresh
Permission errors (Mac)	Use <code>sudo npm install -g</code> or install via nvm

Step 3: Install Claude Code

Claude Code is Anthropic's AI coding assistant that runs directly in your terminal. It can read your project, write code, run commands, and build entire apps conversationally.

Prerequisites

- Node.js 18+ (we just installed this)
- An Anthropic API key from <https://console.anthropic.com>

Install

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Verify

```
claude --version
```

First-Time Setup

1. Run `claude` in any directory
2. It will ask for your Anthropic API key
3. Paste your key — it gets stored securely in your system keychain
4. You're in! You can now chat with Claude Code in your terminal

Quick Test

```
mkdir test-project && cd test-project
claude
# Type: "Create a hello world index.js file"
```

If it creates the file, Claude Code is working.

Step 4: Install ServiceNow SDK

The ServiceNow SDK lets you build ServiceNow apps as TypeScript code (instead of clicking through the UI). The AI tools will generate this code for us.

Prerequisites

- Node.js 18+ ■
- NPM ■
- A ServiceNow developer instance (free at <https://developer.servicenow.com>)

Install

```
npm install -g @servicenow/sdk
```

Verify

```
now-sdk --version
```

Set Up Authentication

Connect the SDK to your ServiceNow instance:

```
now-sdk auth save mydev --host https://YOUR-INSTANCE.servicenow.com --username admin --default
```

Replace **YOUR-INSTANCE** with your actual instance name. It will prompt for your password.

Scaffold a Test App

```
npx @servicenow/sdk init
```

Follow the prompts to create a new app. This confirms the SDK is properly installed.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
<code>now-sdk: command not found</code>	Close and reopen terminal, or check npm global path

Auth fails	Double-check instance URL and credentials. Make sure your instance is awake
EACCES permission error	On Mac: <code>sudo npm install -g @servicenow/sdk</code> or use nvm

Step 5 (Optional): Install GitHub Copilot

If you want to use GitHub Copilot as your AI assistant (we'll use it in Part 3):

Prerequisites

- A GitHub account
- A Copilot subscription (free for students, or \$10/month individual)

Install

1. Open **VS Code**
2. Go to **Extensions** (Cmd+Shift+X on Mac, Ctrl+Shift+X on Windows)
3. Search for "**GitHub Copilot**"
4. Click **Install**
5. Also install "**GitHub Copilot Chat**"
6. Sign in with your GitHub account when prompted

Verify

1. Create a new file called `test.js`
2. Start typing `function hello` — Copilot should suggest a completion in gray
3. Press **Tab** to accept

If you see suggestions appearing, Copilot is working.

Step 6 (Optional): Install Windsurf

Windsurf is an AI-native code editor (we'll use it in Part 4):

Mac

1. Go to <https://windsurf.com>
2. Download for Mac

3. Open the `.dmg` and drag to Applications
4. Open Windsurf and sign up / sign in

Windows

1. Go to <https://windsurf.com>
2. Download for Windows
3. Run the installer
4. Open Windsurf and sign up / sign in

Verify

Open Windsurf. You should see the AI chat panel on the right side. Try asking it something — if it responds, you're good.

Setup Complete — What's Next?

Your environment is ready. Here's what we installed:

- | | |
|------------------|--------------------------------------|
| ■ VS Code | – our code editor |
| ■ Node.js + NPM | – runtime and package manager |
| ■ Claude Code | – AI assistant in the terminal |
| ■ ServiceNow SDK | – build SN apps as code |
| ■ GitHub Copilot | – AI assistant in VS Code (optional) |
| ■ Windsurf | – AI-native editor (optional) |

The App We're Building

In Parts 2–4, we'll build the same app three different ways:

AI Agent Management System — a ServiceNow app that tracks AI agents in your organization:

- **AI Agents table** — name, description, status (active/inactive), type (autonomous/assisted), owner, connected asset in CMDB
- **Agent Tools table** — name, description, type (tool/sub-agent), parent agent, what it does

This connects to your CMDB so you know which infrastructure your AI agents are running on.

Next: [Part 2 — Build with Claude Code →](#)